

# COGNITIVE BEHAVIORAL THERAPY (CBT) – SESSION 4

New Patient: Meera – Highly Detailed Version  
Full Detailed – Realistic Style with Greater Depth

## SESSION INFORMATION

|                   |                                                          |                   |                                            |
|-------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|-------------------|--------------------------------------------|
| <b>Client:</b>    | Meera (28 years, Female, High School Teacher, Therapist) | <b>Therapist:</b> | Dr. A.                                     |
| <b>Session #:</b> | 4 of 16–18                                               | <b>Focus:</b>     | Behavioral Activation + Deeper Exploration |

## PRE-SESSION THERAPIST NOTES

Client arrived looking even more fatigued than last session. She spoke very little at the beginning and avoided eye contact. She completed the diary on 4 days and managed only one 5-minute activity. She expressed strong hopelessness and self-criticism. Today's plan: Explore her experience with Behavioral Activation in depth, validate the difficulty, continue with extremely small steps, deepen cognitive restructuring, and assign very manageable homework.

## SESSION START – CHECKING IN WITH COMPASSION

**Therapist:** Good morning, Meera. It's good to see you again. How have you been feeling this week?

**Client:** (speaking in a flat, low voice, looking down) Same as before. Tired. I tried to do the small activity but only managed it once. I feel like I'm wasting your time and my own. Nothing is changing.

**Therapist:** (speaking gently and slowly) I can hear how heavy and hopeless this feels for you right now. It sounds exhausting to keep trying when it feels like nothing is moving. I want you to know that what you're describing — the extreme fatigue, the harsh self-judgment, the sense that nothing will change — is very common in depression. It doesn't mean you're failing. It means depression is still very strong right now. Would it be okay if we talked about what happened with the small activities without judging it?

**Client:** (quietly, with a slight shrug) I guess.

## EXPLORING THE HOMEWORK EXPERIENCE IN DEPTH

**Therapist:** You mentioned you only managed one 5-minute activity this week. Can you tell me what that activity was and what it felt like before, during, and after?

**Client:** (speaking slowly) On Wednesday, I made a cup of tea mindfully after school. Before doing it, I kept thinking "This is stupid. What's the point?" But I forced myself because I said I would try. While making the tea, I was mostly thinking about how tired I was and how I still had papers to check. After drinking it, I didn't feel any better. I just felt annoyed with myself for not doing more.

**Therapist:** Thank you for sharing that so honestly. It sounds like even when you managed to do the activity, your mind was still very critical and the depression made it hard to feel any benefit. That must have been disappointing. When you had the thought "This is stupid. What's the point?", how did that affect your motivation and energy in that moment?

**Client:** It made me feel even more tired and hopeless. Like even trying is pointless. So I didn't try again for the rest of the week.

**Therapist:** That makes a lot of sense. The thought "What's the point?" is very powerful when someone is depressed. It acts like a brake on any small movement. And then when you don't do the activity, the self-criticism gets louder, which makes everything feel even heavier. This is a very common cycle. Does seeing it this way help at all, or does it still feel like you're just failing?

**Client:** (after a pause) A bit. I can see how the thoughts are making it harder. But I still feel like I should be able to do more.

## CONTINUING BEHAVIORAL ACTIVATION – MAKING IT EVEN SMALLER

**Therapist:** Given how difficult even 5-minute activities felt this week, I want to suggest something even gentler. Instead of setting a fixed activity every day, we can focus on **noticing** one very small thing you did each day — even things like brushing your teeth, reaching school, or making tea. The goal is to start training your attention toward small actions rather than forcing yourself to do "extra" things when your energy is this low. How does that sound?

**Client:** (sounding slightly less resistant) That feels a bit easier. Because I'm already doing some of those things anyway. I just don't notice them.

**Therapist:** Exactly. Depression often makes us ignore the small things we're still managing to do and only focus on what we're not doing. This exercise is about gently shifting that focus. Would you be willing to try noticing and writing down one small thing you did each day this week?

**Client:** I can try that. It doesn't feel as overwhelming as before.

## CONTINUING COGNITIVE RESTRUCTURING WITH DEPTH

**Therapist:** Last session we looked at the thought "I'm not good enough as a teacher." You said you still believe it around 65%. Can we explore this thought a bit more today? When this thought is strong, what does it make you feel in your body and emotionally?

**Client:** It makes my chest feel heavy and tight. I feel ashamed and small. Like I want to disappear. And then I just want to sleep so I don't have to think about it.

**Therapist:** That sounds really painful. When you feel that shame and heaviness, what does the thought tell you to do?

**Client:** To hide. To not talk to anyone. To just get through the day without anyone noticing how bad I feel.

**Therapist:** And when you follow what the thought says — hiding and withdrawing — how does that affect your mood and energy afterward?

**Client:** It makes everything worse. I feel more alone and more tired.

**Therapist:** So the thought "I'm not good enough" leads to shame and hiding, which then leads to even lower mood and more isolation. This is a very painful cycle. Would it be okay if we looked at what might go against this thought — even small pieces of evidence — without forcing you to believe something you don't feel yet?

**Client:** (quietly) Okay.

**Therapist:** What are some small things — even very small — that might suggest you're not completely "not good enough" as a teacher? Even if they feel hard to hold on to right now.

**Client:** (after thinking) Some students still greet me in the morning. One girl came and told me she understood a topic better because of my class. My mother sometimes says I work very hard. But these things feel small compared to how bad I feel.

**Therapist:** Those are real things, even if they feel small right now. Depression has a way of making the negative feel huge and the positive feel tiny or invisible. This doesn't mean the positive things aren't real — it just means the depression is filtering them out. You don't have to believe the balanced thought fully yet. We're just collecting evidence slowly.

## HOMEWORK ASSIGNMENT

**Therapist:** For this week, I want to keep everything as gentle as possible:

1. Continue the daily mood + thought diary (even 4 entries is fine)
2. Notice and write down **one small thing** you did each day (even basic things like reaching school or making tea)
3. Continue rating your belief in the thought "I'm not good enough as a teacher" and gently using the balanced thought we created

**Client:** I'll try. But I'm still not sure how much energy I'll have.

**Therapist:** That's completely okay. Just do what you can. We'll work with whatever you bring, without any judgment.

## SESSION SUMMARY & FEEDBACK

**Therapist:** Today we explored your experience with the small activities in more depth, and we looked at how the thought "I'm not good enough" affects your emotions and behavior. How are you feeling about today's session?

**Client:** It was okay. Talking about it made me realize how much the thoughts are affecting me. I'll try noticing the small things I do.

**Therapist:** That's completely fair. Any questions before we finish?

**Client:** Not really.

## POST-SESSION THERAPIST NOTES

- Client arrived with high fatigue and strong hopelessness. Emotional depth was explored more than in previous sessions.
- Behavioral Activation continued with very small, compassionate steps.
- Client showed some insight into how thoughts affect behavior but remains skeptical about improvement.
- Belief in core thought remains stable around 65%.
- Next session: Review noticing small activities, continue cognitive restructuring with more depth, explore values or small sources of meaning if energy allows.

*Disclaimer: This is a completely fictional but realistic simulation created solely for educational and AI training purposes. It does not represent any real person or therapy.*